THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

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CHAPTER ONE

What I Thought Losing Meant

I loved baseball before I understood very much about winning.

I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a pretty good place and time to fall in love with the game. The Indians were loaded. Kenny Lofton. Albert Belle. Omar Vizquel. The city had waited long enough for a championship that every good team carried a little extra hope with it.

They made the World Series twice during that decade and lost both times.

As a kid, I was not sitting around thinking about the psychology of being close to winning. I wanted my team to win. When they did not, it hurt. When they got close and did not, it seemed to hurt more.

That was about as sophisticated as my understanding was.

I loved playing too. I watched games, practiced, played pickup ball with friends and spent time at batting cages. When I went to the library with my dad, I would grab baseball books along with whatever else had my attention. Nolan Ryan's *Pitcher's Bible* is one I remember because I read it closely, but there were others.

I was interested in the players, but I was also trying to understand how people got good. Why could one person throw harder? Why could somebody else hit a pitch I could barely see? What changed after somebody practiced something a thousand times?

I doubt I was asking those questions in that language. I was a kid. Mostly I wanted to be better tomorrow than I had been today.

My dad had a pretty straightforward philosophy about that. If something did not work, keep going.

Do not sit around forever feeling sorry for yourself. Figure out what went wrong. Try something else. Get better. Nobody was going to care enough about your situation to climb inside of it and fix your life for you.

I still believe that.

In fact, one of the things I want to be careful about in a book like this is becoming so interested in nuance that I explain responsibility out of the story.

Sometimes you lose because you were not ready. Sometimes somebody practiced more. Sometimes somebody has a skill you do not have yet. Sometimes you got distracted, became lazy, underestimated the competition or convinced yourself that wanting something badly was the same as preparing for it.

Then you meet somebody who wanted it just as badly and had done more.

That happens. There is nothing psychologically complicated about all of those situations. Sometimes somebody beat you, and the honest response is to admit it.

I would rather know that than have somebody protect me from it. If I was not good enough, tell me. If I failed to prepare, tell me. If I did something that put me in a worse position and I can correct it, I want that information.

That part of what my father taught me has served me well.

The part I had to learn later was that responsibility is not the same as pretending everything was within my control.

Baseball started teaching me that before I understood what I was learning.

By the time I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I thought I was ready. At least I was ready according to what I understood preparation to mean at the time.

I had played. I had practiced. I understood the game. I knew I wanted the opportunity.

Then you get around a group of kids who have been preparing for the same thing and you start seeing details you did not know were details.

Some had better equipment. Some had played more organized baseball. Some had access to travel teams, coaching and repetitions that neighborhood pickup games could not completely reproduce.

That did not mean those kids had not worked. They had. It also did not mean I had done nothing. I had worked too.

We had simply arrived at the same tryout through different roads.

I think that was one of the first places I began to understand something I still see in business, athletics and almost every competitive environment I walk into now.

Ambition is not rare.

Wanting the spot feels unique while you are alone imagining yourself in it. Then you walk into a gym with thirty people who want the same spot. You apply for the job with two hundred people who would like the same salary. You send a proposal to a company that has five other people telling them they can solve the same problem.

Desire stops separating people pretty quickly.

Then the smaller things begin to matter. Preparation. Information. Repetition. Coaching. Access. Timing. Talent. Sometimes luck.

At seventeen, I was not thinking about it that way. I wanted to make the team.

And I did.

That part matters to me now because I used to have a habit of retelling old stories according to how they ended. If the ending disappointed me, I allowed the disappointment to reach backward and recolor everything that happened before it.

But I made the team. That happened.

Then I got injured.

I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been.

For years, I probably wanted that sentence to do more work than it needed to. I could make the injury symbolic. I could turn it into a story about destiny or perseverance or the moment one chapter of my life closed so another could open.

I do not know that I experienced it that way.

I was disappointed.

Baseball had occupied enough space in my imagination that losing the opportunity to keep playing required me to figure out what else would occupy that space. For a while, I hated that. Then other interests moved forward. Life started filling itself with different things.

What stayed with me longer was a question I did not know how to ask at the time.

When another player beat me, I could usually find information inside the loss. Maybe he was better. Maybe my timing was off. Maybe I struggled with a certain pitch. Maybe he had more experience. There was something to examine.

The injury did not give me that same kind of information. It ended something without giving me a clean explanation for how I should improve.

That bothered the logic I had grown up with because the logic worked so well in many other places. If you lose, practice more. If you

are not good enough, get better. If the other person has something you do not have, go build it.

But what do you do when effort is not the missing piece?

I had done enough to make the team. I still did not get the season I wanted. Both were true.

That sounds simple to me now, but I have noticed how uncomfortable people can become when two things are true at the same time.

We prefer cleaner stories. The winner worked harder. The loser did not want it enough. The company succeeded because its leaders made better decisions. The company failed because its leaders made worse ones. The marriage lasted because the people chose correctly. The relationship ended because something must have been wrong from the beginning.

Sometimes those explanations are accurate.

Sometimes we start with the ending and work backward until we have created a story that makes the ending look inevitable.

Winning gets treated that way too.

Once somebody becomes successful, everything they did before success starts looking important. Their morning routine mattered. The book they read mattered. Their discipline mattered. Their coach mattered. The fact that they woke up at 4:30 mattered.

Maybe all of those things really did matter.

But I eventually became interested in a question we ask much less often: how many people did similar things and never got the same result?

At seventeen, none of this was in my head.

I just knew baseball was slowly becoming something I used to do. Other interests took its place. I got older. Eventually I found myself

teaching, coaching, building businesses, becoming a husband and father and watching my own sons care deeply about sports.

And as the losses became more expensive, I started returning to something that injury had introduced much earlier.

What does a loss actually prove?

I used to think the answer was almost always about what I needed to fix. Now I think the answer depends on the loss.

Sometimes it proves quite a bit. If somebody was better, I want to learn from that. If I was lazy, I need to admit it. If I failed to prepare, I need to prepare differently.

But sometimes a loss tells me very little about my ability. Sometimes it tells me more about access, timing or circumstances. Sometimes it tells me the game I am playing is not giving me what I thought winning it would give me. Sometimes the loss is the result of a decision I made because staying would have cost more than leaving.

And sometimes something happens and I genuinely do not know what it means yet.

I wish I had understood that earlier, although I am not sure I would have listened.

When people care about us, they often want to make pain useful as quickly as possible. Everything happens for a reason. God has something better. This is making you stronger. Keep your head up.

I understand those sentences because I have said them.

I am a Christian. I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I have lived long enough to look back at certain events and see something valuable that I absolutely could not see while they were happening.

I also do not think my faith requires me to pretend I understand the purpose of every painful experience. Those are different claims.

There are things that redirected me. There are things that eventually became material for something else. There are things I lost that I would still prefer not to have lost.

I have become more comfortable letting all three of those statements live together.

What concerns me now is how quickly we can move from experiencing a loss to trying to repair ourselves.

If another person beats me because they are better, improvement makes sense. If the margin was so close that the outcome could easily have moved the other way, I should probably be careful about rebuilding my entire approach because of one result. If something was taken from me because another person or system made a decision outside my control, endlessly searching myself for the flaw that caused it can become punishment instead of accountability. If I am winning a game I no longer want to play, working harder may make me more successful and less happy at the same time. And if I decided to leave because the price of staying changed, calling myself a quitter may completely misunderstand what I did.

Those are not the same losses.

I did not know any of that when I was seventeen.

What I knew was what my dad taught me: get back up.

I am glad he taught me that. Movement has saved me more than once, and I hope some version of that instinct lives in my sons too.

What I had to learn later was that getting back up and knowing where to go are two different skills.

It took me a while to see the difference.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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